

Theoretical Preparations (Overture): Philosophical Terminology

I. TERMINOLOGY PT. I (BRANDING)

Philosophical Terminology

- * Philosophical terminology asks what kind of problem is encapsulated in a term.
- * Each concept carries a hidden question that thinkers across time have tried to answer.
- * As Schelling, a German Idealist, once said: every concept contains its own opposite.
- * A term like “subject” always implies the idea of an “object.”

Philosophical Terminology

- * To define a concept, we must grasp it as a difference—something that only gains meaning in contrast to what it is not.
- * Who says “summer” also means “winter.”
- * Who says “man” also says “woman.”
- * Who says “freedom” also implies “unfreedom” or “slavery.”
- * Who says “yin” ...

Philosophical Terminology

- * Philosophical schools can also be arranged in opposites.
The three main pairs are:

Idealism	Rationalism	Spiritualism
Realism	Empiricism	Materialism

Philosophical Terminology

- * One term usually stands as the alternative to the other.
- * **But don't make the mistake of assigning every philosopher neatly to one side!**
- * These labels are only rough guideposts—*topoi*.
- * In most cases, you cannot say: this thinker belongs strictly here, not there. What matters is ... ?

Philosophical Terminology

- * What matters is the **shared core problem** they're all grappling with.
- * Is Descartes a rationalist?
- * Is Bacon an empiricist?

Philosophical Terminology

- * What matters is the **shared core problem** they're all grappling with.
- * Is Descartes a rationalist?
- * Is Bacon an empiricist?
- * Yes and yes—but above all, **they were philosophers.**

Philosophical Terminology

- * All schools argue—but Hegel reminds us: **philosophy is a unified movement of the idea.**
- * So don't overestimate the labels.
- * Don't reduce a philosophy to a “brand” or slogan.
- * **Real thinking happens in the argument**, in the ideas—not in where you file them.

Opposites and Weight in Yin-Yang

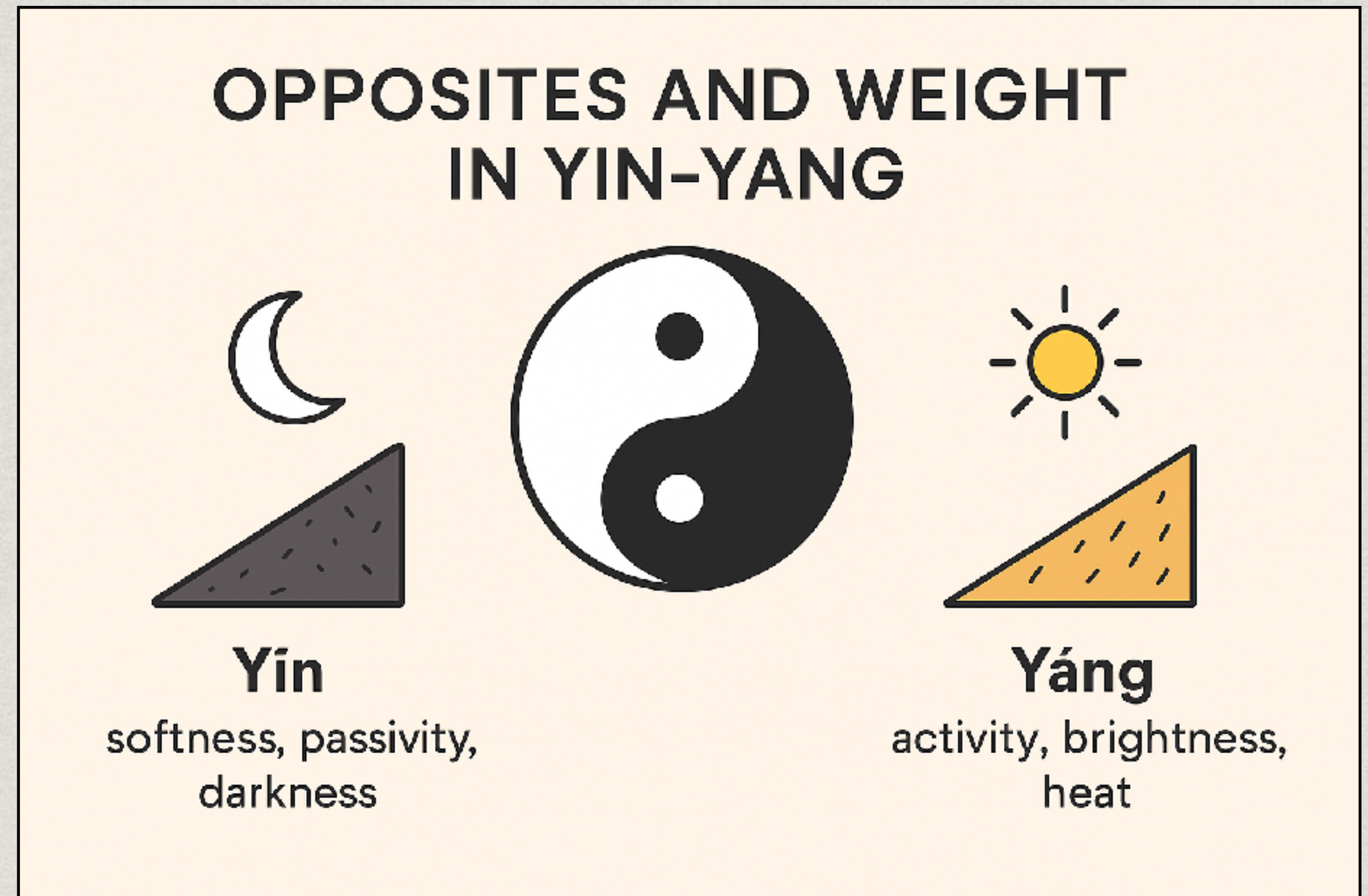
- * YE Huiyuan's critique: *"Yīn" in "yin-yang" isn't specifically meant to represent something of female. In "阴阳", 月 means the moon, 日 means the sun. In Chinese thought, yīn and yáng represent complementary forces—a kind of balance between soft and strong aspects of things. Though they are sometimes used to describe male and female qualities, their meaning is much broader and comes from dialectical thinking in traditional Chinese philosophy. That's what I think.*
- * Focus: opposites and complementary forces, not just gender!
- * **Yīn**: softness, passivity, darkness, water
- * **Yáng**: activity, brightness, heat, fire
- * Often, one side is given more weight or importance.

Symbolic Associations

- * Moon → yin side; sun → yang side
- * Moon: female qualities → reflection, receptivity, nurturing rhythms
- * Sun: male qualities → brightness, boldness, assertiveness
- * Based on natural cycles: day/night, light/dark, warmth/coolness

Historical Meaning of Yīn

- * Originally, yīn ≠ moon; meant shady, north-facing slope
- * Question: for a farmer, which slope is “better”?
- * Sunlit slope → better for crops, growth, productivity
- * Shady slope → cooler, damp, useful for some plants/livestock
- * Suggests implicit value judgment in yin-yang symbolism



Implicit Ranking and Natural Logic

- * Yáng = sunny side → brightness, growth, activity → prized by humans
- * Yīn = shady side → quiet, cool, passive → secondary, hidden potential
- * Moon linked to yin later: soft, reflective, yielding
- * Sun linked to yang: bright, assertive, masculine qualities Suggests implicit value judgment in yin-yang symbolism

Takeaways

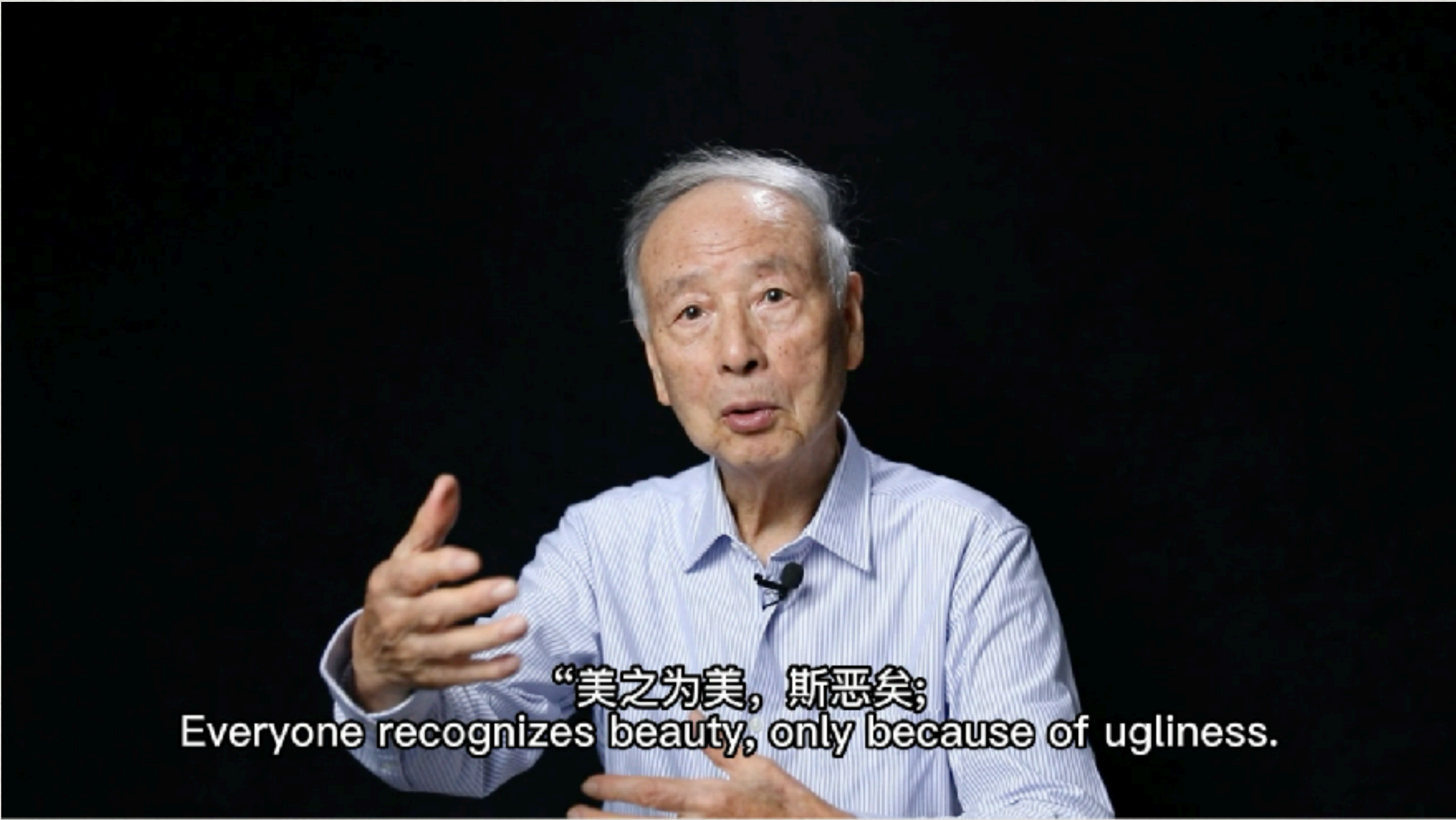
- * Yin-Yang goes beyond male/female labels
- * Early symbolic logic shaped by **natural observation**
- * Demonstrates how cultural ideas emerge from human-environment interaction
- * Subtle ranking reflects human preferences for productivity, light, and activity

CHEN GUYING

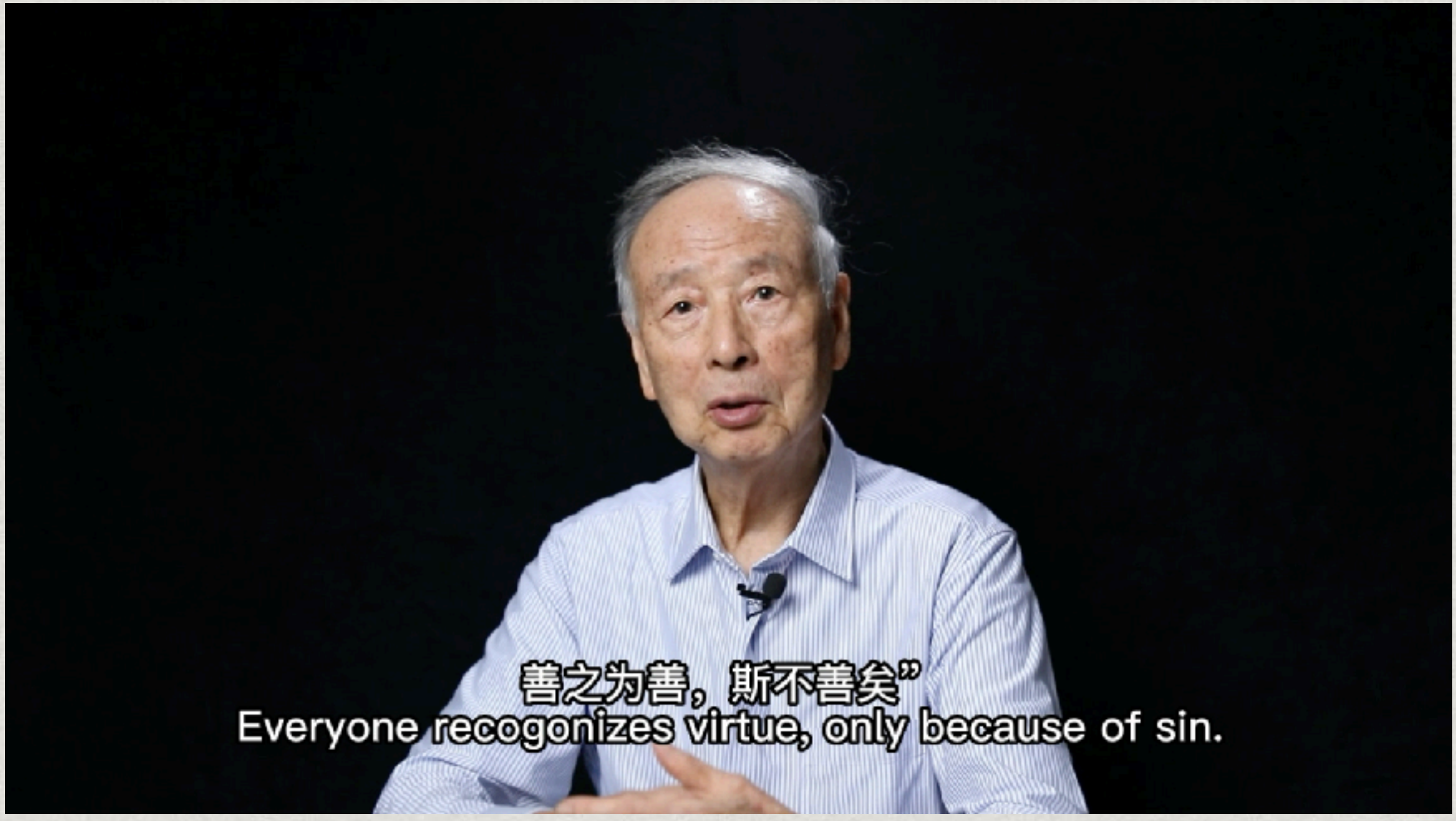




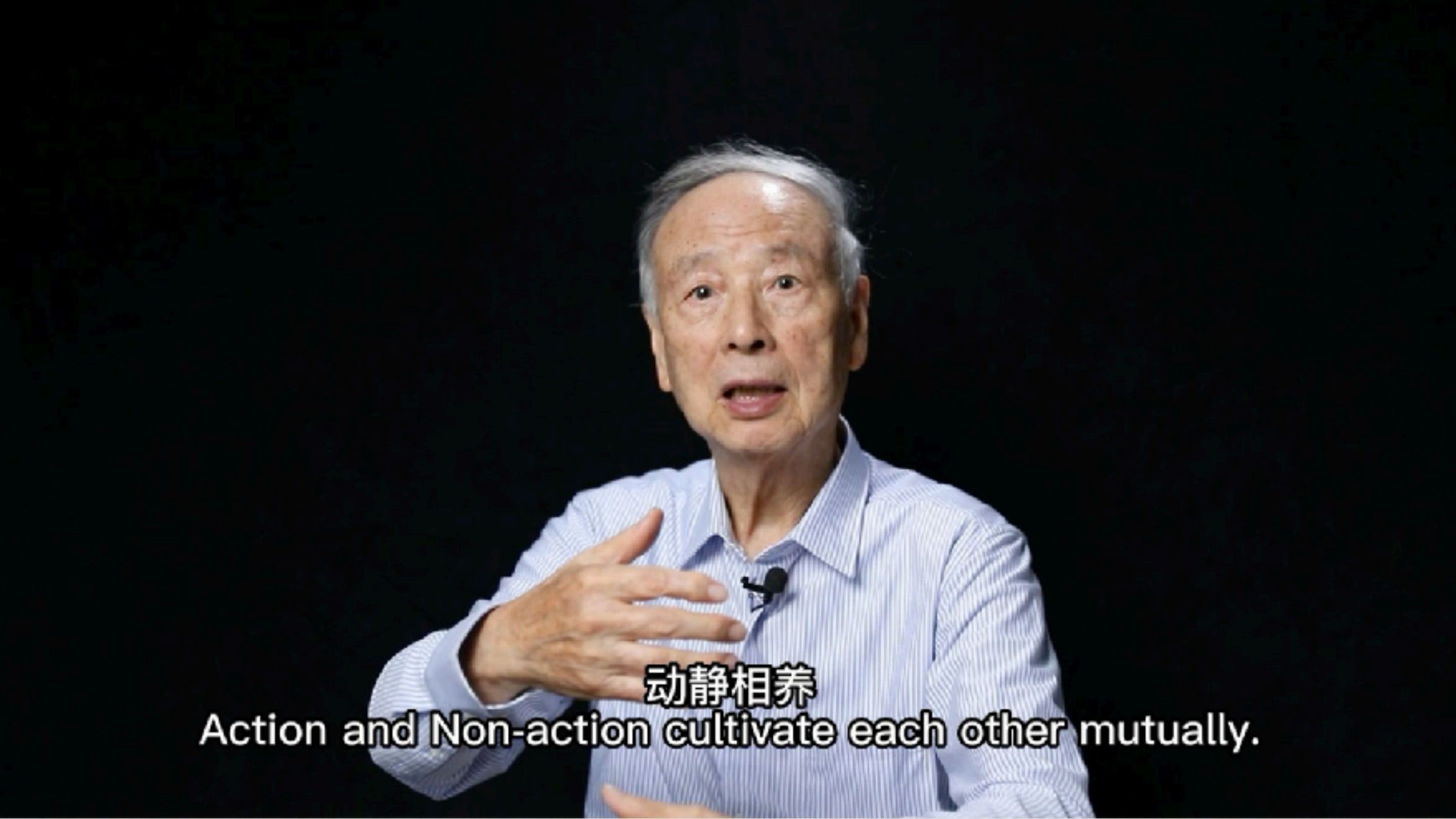
那么就有像老子讲的啊
Laozi said,



“美之为美，斯恶矣；
Everyone recognizes beauty, only because of ugliness.



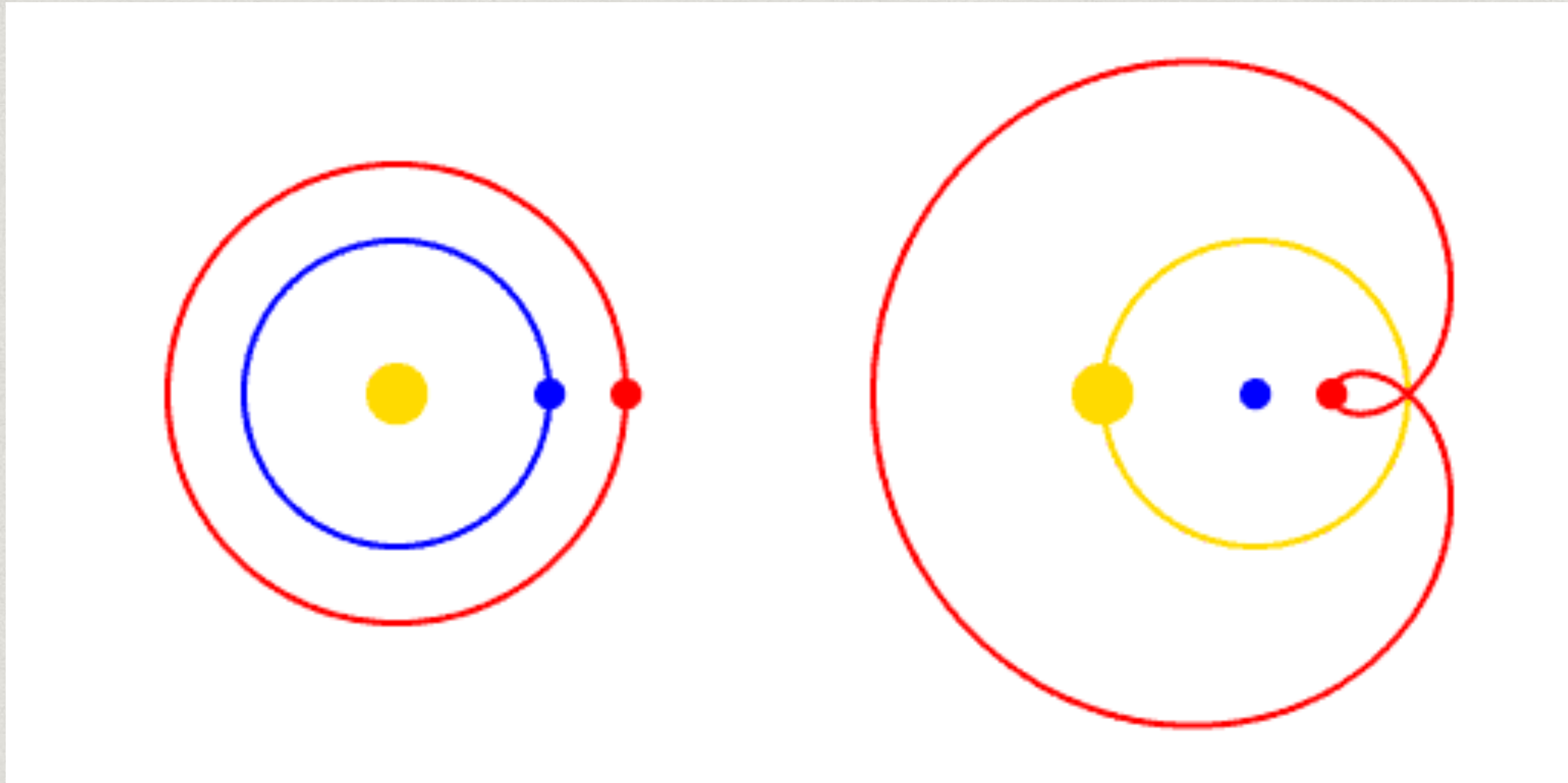
善之为善，斯不善矣”
Everyone recognizes virtue, only because of sin.



动静相养
Action and Non-action cultivate each other mutually.

II. COPERNICAN TURN I.E. MINDFULNESS

Copernican Turn



Copernican Turn



- * Copernicus moved the sun to the center of our—hence the name—**solar system**.
- * This radical shift changed how we understand our place in the universe. This is why we speak of a ‘revolution’.

Copernican Turn

- * Kant spoke of a similar "Copernican turn"—in his *Critique of Pure Reason* (1787)—but in philosophy.
- * For Kant, the big idea is this: we don't just adjust to nature's laws.
- * Instead ... ?

Copernican Turn

- * Kant spoke of a similar "Copernican turn"—in his *Critique of Pure Reason* (1787)—but in philosophy.
- * For Kant, the big idea is this: we don't just adjust to nature's laws.
- * Instead, **nature** (or the world as we know it) **follows the laws of our mind**.

Mindfulness

- * The name of this shift: **Idealism.**
- * But what is meant by “our mind”?

Ordering the Major Schools of Thought

- * Let's try to bring some order to all of this.
- * In **Idealism**, mind—or mental representation—is the guiding principle.
- * In **Realism**, the principle is **reality as something that exists independently of our consciousness**.
- * These are two fundamentally opposed positions.

Ordering the Major Schools of Thought

- * **Rationalism** holds pure reason—thinking independent of experience—as its principle.
- * **Empiricism** puts experience first—but how do we experience? Through our senses.
- * **Spiritualism** sees mind or spirit as the fundamental principle.
- * **Materialism** sees matter as primary, opposed to the mind.

Are These Really Principles?

- * How can these terms help us learn to think?
- * For starters, we can ask whether each of them truly functions as a “principle.”
- * “Mind,” perhaps—but is “experience” really a single, unifying ground?
- * David Hume’s famous observation was: **experience is scattered and multiple—the opposite of a principle.**

“For my part, when I enter most intimately into what I call myself, I always stumble on some particular perception or other, of heat or cold, light or shade, love or hatred, pain or pleasure. I never can catch myself at any time without a perception, and never can observe anything but the perception. When my perceptions are removed for any time, as by sound sleep; so long am I insensible of myself, and may truly be said not to exist. And were all my perceptions removed by death, and could I neither think, nor feel, nor see, nor love, nor hate, after the dissolution of my body, I should be entirely annihilated, nor do I conceive what is further requisite to make me a perfect non-entity. If anyone, upon serious and unprejudiced reflection, thinks he has a different notion of himself, I must confess I can reason no longer with him. All I can allow him is, that he may be in the right as well as I, and that we are essentially different in this particular. But setting aside some metaphysicians of this kind, I may venture to affirm of the rest of mankind, that they are nothing but a bundle or collection of different perceptions, which succeed each other with an inconceivable rapidity, and are in a perpetual flux and movement.”

–David Hume

III. PHILOSOPHY VS. SCIENCE

“Philosophy”

- ✱ **Greek origin:** The word comes from ancient Greek φιλοσοφία (**philosophía**).

“Philosophy”

- * It has two roots:
- * **φίλος (phílos)** = “loving,” “fond of,” “friend.”
- * **σοφία (sophía)** = “wisdom,” “knowledge,” “skill”.
- * **Literal meaning:** philosophía = “love of wisdom.”

“Philosophy”

- * **Earliest use:** Attributed to **Pythagoras (6th century BCE)**, who allegedly described himself not as a “wise man” (sophos), but as a “lover of wisdom” (*philosophos*).
- * Originally referred broadly to the pursuit of knowledge and understanding of the world. In classical Greece, it came to denote systematic inquiry into **nature, existence, ethics, and knowledge**.
- * **Latin adoption:** The Romans adopted the Greek term directly as **philosophia**, which then passed into Old French and Middle English as philosophie.
- * **Modern usage:** Today, “philosophy” denotes **both an academic discipline and a general attitude or framework of thought (see Andy Warhol)**.

Science vs. Philosophy

Science

- * **Empirical:** Science tests claims against observation and experiment.
- * **Method-driven:** It uses hypotheses, measurements, and reproducibility.
- * **Progressive:** Knowledge is cumulative, with old theories refined or discarded when evidence contradicts them.

Philosophy

- * **Conceptual & critical:** Philosophy examines the assumptions, concepts, and logic behind knowledge.
- * **Normative questions:** Science tells us what is; philosophy also asks what ought to be (ethics, aesthetics, politics).
- * **Meta-level:** Philosophy asks what counts as knowledge, truth, evidence — the very foundations of science itself.

Hume and Neuroscience

- * **No single "self-center":** Neuroscience has not found a central “self” in the brain. Instead, brain imaging shows networks distributed across regions that contribute to memory, sensory processing, emotions, and self-representation. This lines up with Hume’s idea that what we call the self is a **bundle of perceptions**.
- * **Default Mode Network (DMN):** The DMN is active when we engage in self-referential thought (daydreaming, autobiographical memory, imagining the future). But it’s a network, not a core self. Damage or disruption (e.g., in meditation or psychedelics) often results in a diminished sense of a continuous self — again, more Humean.
- * **Split-brain patients:** After severing the corpus callosum, patients can show two streams of consciousness that are not unified. This suggests the "unity" of experience is constructed, fragile, and contingent — not absolute. Hume would nod here.
- * **Neuroconstructivism:** Perception itself is fragmented; the brain integrates different sensory modules asynchronously. So the "now" we experience is already a stitching-together job.

Kant and Neuroscience

- ✱ **Binding problem & predictive processing:** The brain does seem to need mechanisms that bind disparate sensory inputs into a coherent, usable whole. Kant's idea that the mind contributes form to otherwise scattered impressions (categories like causality, time, space) resonates with how the brain imposes structure.
- ✱ **Global Workspace Theory (Baars, Dehaene):** Conscious experience emerges when disparate neural processes get "broadcast" into a global workspace. That is a bit Kantian: **something** is unifying scattered inputs into a structured conscious scene.
- ✱ **Sense of agency & narrative self:** While no single "I" is found, the brain does generate a sense of agency and continuity, **often by retrospective narrative stitching**. Some see this as echoing Kant's "transcendental unity," though neuroscience interprets it as a function, not a metaphysical necessity.

So ... ?

- * **Closer to Hume:** Neuroscience generally undermines the idea of a metaphysical self, supporting the view that "self" is a construct arising from multiple processes. This maps onto Hume's "bundle of perceptions."
- * **But with a Kantian twist:** At the same time, the brain's binding and predictive mechanisms give experience a **unity and structure** — not because of a transcendental subject (a kind of 'backstage I' that organizes everything we experience), but because cognition needs it to survive. In that sense, neuroscience naturalizes Kant: it explains how unity happens without postulating a noumenal "I."
- * **Neuroscience sides more with Hume on the absence of a core self, but it also explains (in a Kant-compatible way) why we experience unity.** If Hume said "no self, just perceptions," and Kant said "unity requires an 'I think'," neuroscience says: "there's no metaphysical self, but the brain cobbles together enough unity for practical purposes."

The Answer: History

- * Historically, what we now call science was once called natural philosophy.
- * **Philosophy gives science its framework:** The philosophy of science defines concepts like "falsifiability" (Popper) or "paradigm shift" (Kuhn).
- * **Science informs philosophy:** Discoveries in neuroscience, cosmology, AI, etc. reshape philosophical debates about mind, reality, ethics.
- * Philosophy is not science—because it doesn't rely on empirical testing in the same systematic way.
- * It's science's companion—providing the groundwork, concepts, and critical reflection that allow science to exist and to understand itself.